Study Guide

The Odyssey

Lecture 1
Ithaca

Suggested Readings

- Homer, *The Odyssey*, trs. Robert Fagles, Book 1

Outline

0:00-10:52 —Epic Invocation and Background

- The *Odyssey* is an epic poem from archaic Greece, composed by Homer around the year 750 BC. It is set in an older period, around 1100 or 1200 BC.
- The first 12 lines of the poem, beginning with the words "Sing to me, Muse," form the proem, an epic invocation and prayer to a goddess for inspiration.
- Odysseus, "the man of twists and turns," is on a journey back from Troy, the setting of Homer's other epic poem, the *Iliad*.
    - The war begins over Helen, the most beautiful woman in the world, who was abducted by Paris of Troy from her Greek husband, Menelaus.
    - The greatest hero of the Greek army, Achilles, faces an explicit choice in the *Iliad*: die in battle but win undying fame and glory, *kleos*, or survive and have a triumphant homecoming, a *nostos* with less glory. He chooses *kleos*.
    - After ten years of war, Odysseus devises the stratagem of hiding warriors inside a wooden horse to breach the walls of Troy.



10:53-20:03 —Odysseus

- The *Odyssey* begins *in medias res* (in the middle of things). It has been 9 years since the sack of Troy.
- Odysseus is called *polytropos*, the "man of twists and turns." That can signify the many twists and turns along his journey home or the twists and turns of his *metis* or "cunning."
- Odysseus is not mentioned by name for nearly 25 lines unlike Achilles, who is named in the first line of the *Iliad*. This delay shows that Odysseus is slow to reveal himself.

- Odysseus is both beloved and hated by divine beings.
    - The nymph, Calypso wants him for her husband.
    - Poseidon, the brother of Zeus, is bent on Odysseus's destruction.
- Calypso's love for Odysseus threatens the hero's marriage to Penelope. This introduces the theme of marriage and its relation the political order.

20:04-34:03 — Olympus and Ithaca

- In Zeus's speech to the gods on Mount Olympus, he complains that men unjustly blame the gods for suffering they have brought on themselves.



- Telemachus is the son of Odysseus. An infant when Odysseus left, he is now 19 and still waiting for his father's return.
- While Odysseus has been away at Troy, his wife Penelope is plagued with suitors seeking her hand in marriage. She does not accept, nor does she send them away. Instead, they eat and drink Odysseus' food and abuse his servants for years.
- Athena appears to Telemachus disguised as a wayfarer.
    - According to the Greek custom of *xenia,* or "hospitality," Telemachus attends to his guest during a feast for the suitors.
    - *Xenia*, a sacred and important virtue to Zeus, demanded the traveler receive food, lodging, and washing from his host and the host receive news of the world or entertainment from his guest. It helped maintain peace between strangers.
- Athena inspires Telemachus and encourages him to journey in search of news of his father. He realizes the goddess's divine identity when she flies off like a bird.

Key Terms

Kleos (κλέος) – glory, undying fame

Metis (μῆτις) – cunning, skill, wisdom

Nostos (νοστος) – triumphant return home

Xenia (ξενία) – hospitality

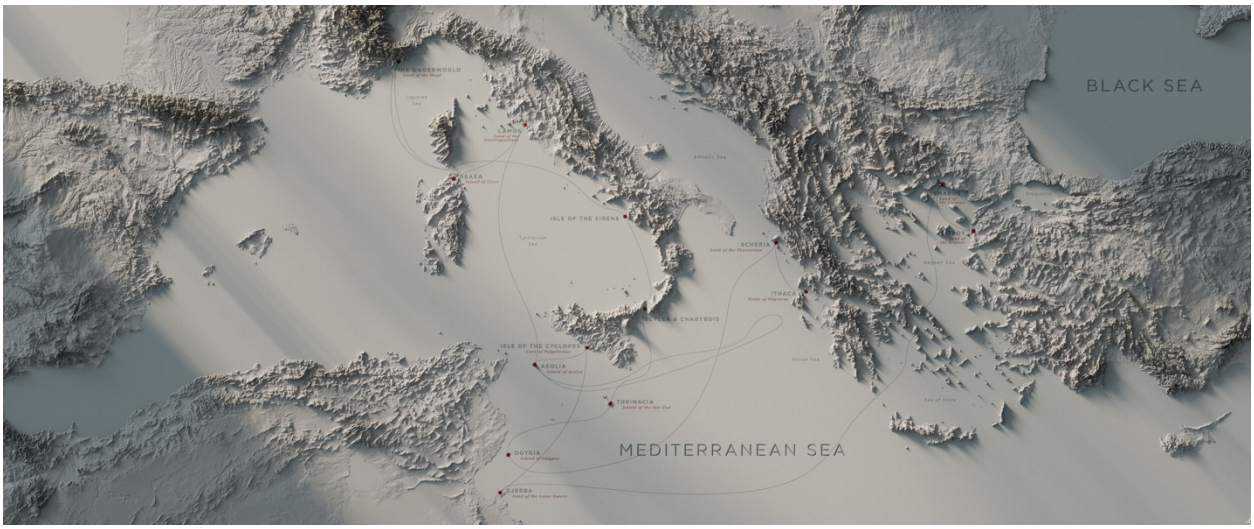


Key Passages

Sing to me of the man, Muse, the man of twists and turns driven time and again off course, once he had plundered the hallowed heights of Troy.

Many cities of men he saw and learned their minds,
many pains he suffered, heartsick on the open sea,
fighting to save his life and bring his comrades home.
But he could not save them from disaster, hard as he strove—
the recklessness of their own ways destroyed them all,
the blind fools, they devoured the cattle of the Sun
and the Sungod blotted out the day of their return.
Launch out on his story, Muse, daughter of Zeus,
start from where you will—sing for our time too.
— Book 1, lines 1-11

Map and Timeline



Discussion Questions

Why did the Greeks consider Odysseus's *metis* a virtue? Is it still considered one in our time?

Does Homer portray Odysseus favorably in the opening lines of the *Odyssey*?

What do Penelope's simultaneous hesitancy to dismiss the suitors and unwillingness to engage with them indicate about her?

Notes